

Incident Response and Change Management Protocol

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Classification: Internal

1. Purpose

This protocol defines the mandatory procedure for responding to production incidents and for approving, executing, and rolling back changes to production systems.

2. Severity Classification

SEV-1: Complete service outage or confirmed data loss. Response within 15 minutes. All-hands bridge required. Executive notification within 1 hour.

SEV-2: Major feature unavailable or severe degradation. Response within 1 hour. On-call engineer plus backup required.

SEV-3: Minor degradation with workaround available. Response within 4 business hours. Handled by on-call engineer.

3. Incident Response Procedure

Step 1: Detect and acknowledge. The on-call engineer acknowledges the alert within the response window and opens an incident ticket.

Step 2: Triage. Classify severity, identify affected services, and assemble the response team. For SEV-1, open the incident bridge immediately.

Step 3: Mitigate. Prefer rollback or feature-flag disablement over forward fixes during active user impact. All mitigation actions are logged in the incident ticket with timestamps.

Step 4: Resolve and verify. Confirm restoration via monitoring and customer-facing checks before closing the incident.

Step 5: Post-mortem. For SEV-1 and SEV-2, a blameless post-mortem is due within 5 business days, covering timeline, root cause, and action items.

4. Change Management Protocol

All production changes require a reviewed pull request, passing CI, and an approved change ticket. Changes are deployed during approved windows only, except emergency fixes for SEV-1/SEV-2, which require on-call manager approval and a retrospective review the next business day.

5. Rollback Protocol

Every deployment must have a tested rollback path. Rollback is initiated automatically if error rates exceed 2x baseline for 10 minutes post-deploy, or manually by the deploying engineer or on-call manager.

6. Communication

SEV-1: status page update every 30 minutes. SEV-2: hourly updates. All incident communications are coordinated by the incident commander; engineers do not communicate directly with customers during an incident.